PERKALATE / FITNESS AND WELLNESS

The Second Visit Problem: Why New Members Fade After Week One

New gym and studio members often stall after a first visit. Here's why blanket discounts don't fix it, and what does.

Most gyms and studios put real money into getting someone through the door the first time. Intro offers, free classes, referral credits, paid social. Then the new member shows up once, maybe twice, and drifts. The membership stays on the books for a while, then quietly cancels.

The first visit gets the attention. The second visit decides whether you've won a member.

Why the second visit is the hard one

The first visit runs on curiosity and a good offer. The second visit runs on habit, and the habit hasn't formed yet. A few things get in the way:

- **The novelty wears off.** The first class is an event. The second is a chore that competes with work, family and a long day.
- **They didn't feel known.** A new member who leaves without anyone noticing them has little reason to think anyone will notice if they don't come back.
- **The timing is wrong.** Many new members try to fit into peak hours, find the class full or the floor crowded, and decide it's not for them.
- **There's no next step.** The intro offer ends and nothing replaces it.

Why discounting to everyone doesn't fix it

The default response is another promotion: a percentage off, a bring a friend week, a sale on class packs. These reach everyone, which means you give money away to loyal members who were coming anyway, while the people at risk of drifting see one more generic email.

Blanket discounts also teach members to wait. If there's always a deal around the corner, nobody needs to commit today. Over time the discount becomes the price.

The off peak connection

The second visit problem and the empty midafternoon class are related. You have capacity sitting idle at certain hours, and you have new members who need a reason to come back. Pointing the right incentive at the right hour addresses both. A new member who comes to a quieter class gets more attention from the instructor, has a better experience, and has a better reason to return.

What a better incentive looks like

A good second visit incentive is:

1. **Targeted.** It goes to verified members who fit a rule, such as new members who have visited once, not to your whole list.
2. **Timed.** It's tied to the hours you want to fill, not the hours that are already full.
3. **Worth something.** A small reward from a brand the member already likes can mean more than a few dollars off a membership.
4. **Funded wisely.** It doesn't have to come out of your margin. Local and national brands want to reach active, health minded people and may fund a reward for them.
5. **Measured.** You know how many members saw it, claimed it and used it.

A quick self check

Look at your last three months of new members and ask:

- What share came back within two weeks?
- What did you send them between visit one and visit two?
- Which classes had open spots during that same window?

If the answers are "not enough," "a generic email" and "plenty," you have a second visit problem and the spare capacity to fix it.

Plan a pilot

Choose one audience, one reward and one result to measure. Set the budget and eligibility rules before launch. Tell participants which information you need and share results in aggregate where possible.